

FEBRUARY 2023



THE VOICE EXPRESS

The Truth Takes Time.

THE VOICE EXPRESS GAZETTE

Absent in the Spring

a novel by

CULTURE

MARY
WESTMACOTT

Absent in the Spring

A review of Agatha Christie's 1944 psychological novel written under the pseudonym Mary Westmacott — a departure from her detective fiction that follows Joan Scudamore, stranded in the Iraqi desert and forced, for the first time, to reckon with the lies she has built her life around.

BY MOULI SHARMA

19 FEBRUARY 2023 · 2 MIN READ



ABOUT

The Voice Express

The Truth Takes Time.

EDITOR IN CHIEF

Mouli

WEB DEVELOPER

Mitali (Aayat Mahnoor)

CONTACT

thevoiceexpress@proton.me

WEBSITE

<https://thevoiceexpress.in>

LOCATION

New Delhi, India

INDEPENDENT • VOLUNTEER-RUN

VOL. 18 • EST. 2022

© 2026

Published in 1944 under the pseudonym Mary Westmacott, *"Absent in the Spring"* is a book by Agatha Christie. The title has been taken from William Shakespeare's Sonnet 98, "From you have I been absent in the spring." The significance of spring is not being able to enjoy the blooming season when a loved one is not there. In contrast to her well-known detective stories, this book offers a psychological exploration of Joan Scudamore, a woman who finds herself left alone in the desert and forced to face her actual nature.

In the 1940s, a middle-aged woman named Joan Scudamore makes a solo trip from Baghdad to Kirkuk to visit her husband, who works for an oil company. She is stranded in her home for a few days because of a sudden sandstorm, and during that time, she starts to think back on her relationships and life. She learns that she has been so preoccupied with trying to satisfy other people and fit in with social norms that she has lost sight of her own wants and individuality. Joan comes to the realization that she has been portraying a fake self to everyone, even her own family, and has been living a lie. When she starts to accept who she really is, Joan's epiphany is both upsetting and empowering.

The book is exquisitely written and displays Christie's talent for telling tales. It digs into the intricacies of interpersonal interactions and the challenges of comprehending one's own emotions and intentions. Readers will identify with Joan's complex and likable character as she attempts to understand her inner conflicts.

In conclusion, "Absent in the Spring" is a challenging and touching book that differs from Christie's typical detective stories yet is no less engrossing. For admirers of Christie's writing and anyone interested in learning more about the human condition, it is a must-read.

ABOUT THE AUTHOR



Mouli Sharma

CONTRIBUTOR

Mouli Sharma is a journalist, freelance illustrator, and writer from New Delhi, India. She is a published photojournalist & illustrator, having been featured in The Hindu College Gazette, & the quarterly Pink Disco. Mouli took over as the Editor of The Voice Express (<https://thevoiceexpress.github.io/e-mag/>) back in September 2023.

<https://thevoiceexpress.github.io/e-mag/> · [Mouli Sharma](#) · [Maktoob Media](#) · [GroundXero](#) · [The Observer Post](#) · [The Leaflet](#) · [Nivarana](#) · [The Polis Project](#) · [Article 14](#) · [Feminism in India](#) · [SabrangIndia](#) · [NewsClick](#) · [Think Global Health](#) · [Hindu College Gazette](#) · [Pink Disco](#) · [The Voice Express](#) · [The Queer Gaze](#)

MORE FROM MOULI SHARMA



Bengal Remembers: Sengar, Epstein, and RG Kar's Legacy on International Women's Day in 2026



'Matters of Money': 43 Organisations Demand India's Withdrawal From Bilateral Investment Agreement with Israel Amidst Ongoing Genocide In Gaza



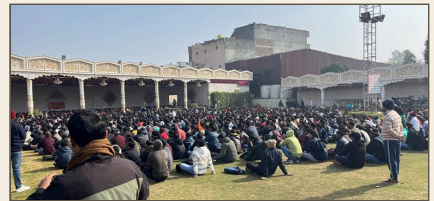
Peaceful Palestine Solidarity Demo in New Delhi Runs Into Rough Weather



'Section 144' at IMT Manesar: Police Violence Against Protesting Maruti Workers Intensifies Ahead of Tripartite Meet, Violates Court Order



"Not Your Footballs!" Newly Formed Union of Non-Permanent Maruti-Suzuki Employees Intensifies Agitation, Calls Out Abuse of Contract Workers



'Equal Work, Equal Pay': 'Temporary' Maruti-Suzuki Workers Establish Union, Join Hands With Protesting Terminated Workers

The Voice Express

The Truth Takes Time.

READER-SUPPORTED JOURNALISM



Read this article online



Support via Razorpay



Read the magazine



The Newsstand